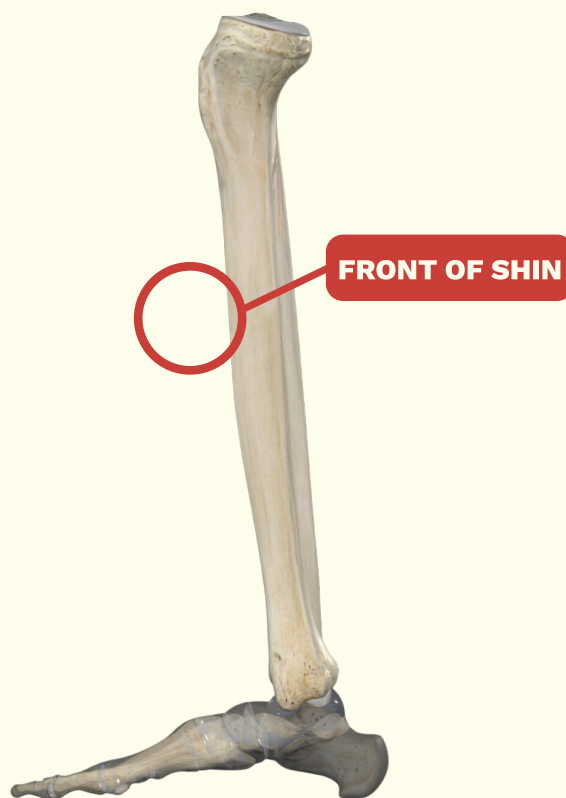


NINE ANTERIOR TIBIAL STRESS FRACTURES. ONE LOOKED LIKE ONE.

A run through the cases I have seen, and what the symptoms actually did.



WHY THIS ONE IS WORTH **TAKING** **SERIOUSLY**

The front of the shin gets little blood supply, and the forces there pull the bone apart rather than squash it. That combination makes it very hard to heal.

10 to 45%

of these patients never return to sport

Plenty end up needing a rod down the shin or a plate across the front to hold it together.

HE PLAYED A GRAND FINAL **ON IT**

PATIENT 1

Shin pain during an AFL season while training for a 15k. Three weeks off concrete, then straight back in. Played the grand final. Played the following season too.

ON TESTING

No marked pain on palpation or hopping at any point after the initial symptoms

BUT

A visible and palpable bone defect on the shin, and severe calf wasting on that side

TIMELINE

Around **18 months** before an accurate diagnosis. Imaging showed it still had not united

SHE RAN A MARATHON BLOCK **PAIN** **FREE**

PATIENT 2

Short lived shin pain that settled quickly. Back to **40 to 50km a week** building for a marathon, essentially pain free the whole way.

Six months later the shin was finally imaged. X-ray, MRI and CT together showed an anterior tibial stress fracture.

Eighteen months on, still not back to full training, because it keeps recurring.

AND IT KEEPS **REPEATING**

PATIENT 3 No pain at rest, running or hopping. **Clear fracture line on both X-ray and CT**

PATIENT 4 Mild shin pain and mild swelling. **Three separate anterior tibial stress fractures**

PATIENT 5 A dull ache when running. **Two anterior stress fractures**

1984 The original reported case described only **very vague shin pain**

THE ONE THAT STOPS **THE ARGUMENT**

PATIENT 6

A 21 year old military officer with anterior tibial stress fractures in **both shins**, and no symptoms in either.

A low trauma trip and fall playing basketball shattered the right tibia.

He was walking around with a broken leg, in one of the most dangerous places to break one, and nothing told him it was there.

ADD THEM UP

Nine anterior tibial stress fractures, and what the symptoms did in each.

3

HAD TRUE SYMPTOMS OF A STRESS FRACTURE

1

PRESENTED THE WAY A TEXTBOOK SAYS IT SHOULD

The other eight were getting on with their season, their marathon block, or their basketball.

SO HERE IS THE QUESTION

Nobody manages a high risk shin by how it feels, because at this site feel does not track what is happening in the bone.

So should it be assumed symptoms are always reliable in the lower risk ones?



That is the next post.